

Footwork wins: Senuran Muthusamy rocks onto the back foot with quiet certainty. It was this simple geometry of movement, once instinctive to Indian batters, that South Africa applied better on turning pitches. AFP

because I think the comparison was that our speeds were a little bit quicker than theirs, that they felt that maybe they needed to be quicker," said Harmer.

The variance in delivery speed offers a snapshot of how South African spinners outthought their counterparts to help their side reign supreme.

Spin leadership

The current Indian spin attack, comprising Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav, Washington Sundar and Axar Patel (only in Kolkata), lacks a lead bowler in the manner R. Ashwin once conducted proceedings in home Tests.

There was also a lack of coherence in the game plan on display. In Guwahati, despite realising that the pitch was not working in their favour, the Indian spinners persisted with their flatter trajectories, with only Kuldeep making a consistent effort to beat batters in the air with drift and dip.

Blunting their wicket-taking potency further were India's conservative field set-ups. For example, in Guwahati, Indian skipper Rishabh Pant had just one close-in catcher for the spinners for most of the morning session on Day 2, despite South Africa being six down. The visiting side's lower order ticked off easy singles as it saw off a tricky phase to set up a massive first-innings total.

Pitch volatility

The current Indian spin quartet has also been forced to bowl in drastically different conditions, thanks to the team management's oscillating pitch choices.

In the West Indies series in October, India played on truer surfaces that held together longer into the Tests.

But after witnessing Indian bowlers being pushed back by Caribbean batters in the second Test



in Delhi, the team management pivoted to a dry surface in Kolkata, which bounced unpredictably right from Day 1.

It proved to be a fatal call, as India lost the toss and had to bat last on a devious pitch, resulting in a collapse and a 30-run defeat.

The Indian think-tank backtracked immediately and opted for a flatter track in Guwahati. But the side lost the toss again and watched South Africa bat it out of the game, with its spinners proving ineffective on unfavourable conditions.

Driving the failure was a lack of adaptability, which proved to be the biggest difference between the two sets of spinners, as suggested by Proteas skipper Temba Bavuma.

Harmer and his spin colleagues averaged just 15.48 in the series, while the Indian tweakers nearly doubled that at 30.33. It was a dramatic flip from the way Tests had unfolded in India over the last decade.

Golden era

India's supremacy at home, which lasted from 2012 to 2024, was

